

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Corporate Strategy English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For corporate strategy, CEO office, transformation, corporate development, strategic finance, product strategy, and internal consulting teams.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Strategic Choices: Ambition, Where to Play, How to Win, and Tradeoffs

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

03 Industry Structure, Competitive Dynamics, and Profit Pools

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

04 Business Models, Unit Economics, Capabilities, and Advantage

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

05 Portfolio Strategy, Capital Allocation, and Resource Reallocation

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

06 Growth Strategy, Market Entry, Partnerships, and M&A Logic

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

07 Uncertainty, Scenarios, Strategic Options, and Risk Posture

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

08 Execution Governance, Operating Model, KPIs, and Board Narrative

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

An executive asks for a "growth strategy" but has not specified whether the priority is revenue, profit, or market entry.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Diagnosis - Explanation of the strategic problem, its cause, and why it matters now.

Ambition - High-level performance or market position the company wants to achieve.

Strategic thesis - Argument for why a course of action should create advantage or value.

Issue tree - Structured breakdown of a problem into analyzable questions.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Improve this sentence: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - B. Could you confirm when the review starts?
 - C. Could you confirm when does the review start?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - B. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?
 - C. Who will present the report at the meeting?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Which growth problem are we solving?

The lesson's executive requests a growth strategy without specifying revenue, profit, or market entry as the priority.

01 • Strategy lead: When you ask for a growth strategy, is the priority revenue, profit, or entry into another market?

02 • Executive sponsor: I haven't chosen among those. I was assuming the same strategy would deliver all three.

03 • Strategy lead: They may involve different choices. Could we clarify the ambition before building a strategic thesis?

04 • Executive sponsor: What would a precise diagnosis add beyond a list of attractive growth initiatives?

05 • Strategy lead: It identifies the problem we're trying to solve, rather than assuming every opportunity addresses it.

06 • Executive sponsor: Then our issue tree should separate those three possible objectives instead of merge them.

07 • Strategy lead: Exactly. We can ask what evidence would make each objective a priority and what constraints apply.

08 • Executive sponsor: Please bring those questions into the discussion without inventing a target or investment budget.

09 • Strategy lead: I will. The immediate output is a clarified decision question, not a fully approved growth direction.

10 • Executive sponsor: Good. Let's establish the objective before requesting initiatives that might answer the wrong question.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Retention or acquisition behind the revenue concern

Separate fictional strategy diagnosis: customer acquisition is unchanged, repeat purchases have fallen, and leadership asks for more advertising. Causes are unconfirmed.

01 • Commercial director: Revenue needs attention. Could you build a strategy around increasing advertising immediately?

02 • Strategy analyst: Before selecting a response, can we clarify the problem? Acquisition is unchanged, while repeat purchases have fallen.

03 • Commercial director: So our diagnosis should examine retention rather than assume new-customer volume caused the weakness.

04 • Strategy analyst: It should investigate repeat purchasing, yes, without claiming we already know why it declined.

05 • Commercial director: Could the issue tree separate purchase frequency, customer loss, and changes in order value?

06 • Strategy analyst: Yes. Those are questions to test, not confirmed causes supplied by the current figures.

07 • Commercial director: What would you ask me to clarify about the ambition for this work?

08 • Strategy analyst: Whether we are prioritizing restored repeat revenue, total revenue growth, or profitability, and over what horizon.

09 • Commercial director: I'll define that objective before treating additional advertising as the strategic thesis.

10 • Strategy analyst: Then we can assess interventions against the actual diagnosis rather than start with a favored solution.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A capacity symptom needs a bounded question

Separate fictional strategy exercise: one service team has a six-week backlog, while capacity elsewhere in the company has not been assessed.

01 • Chief operating officer: One team has a six-week backlog. Should our strategy be to acquire another service company?

02 • Strategy director: Could we first clarify whether the priority is reducing that backlog or expanding long-term capability?

03 • Chief operating officer: I was treating them as the same problem, but the immediate concern is waiting work.

04 • Strategy director: Then our diagnosis should examine demand, capacity, and work flow before selecting an acquisition response.

05 • Chief operating officer: Do we know whether another internal team has spare capacity that could help?

06 • Strategy director: No. Capacity elsewhere hasn't been assessed, so we shouldn't assume either spare resources or universal shortage.

07 • Chief operating officer: Let's frame the issue around the affected service and the six-week backlog first.

08 • Strategy director: Agreed. An issue tree can organize the questions without making the proposed acquisition the answer in advance.

09 • Chief operating officer: I'll clarify the desired service outcome and any constraints for that investigation.

10 • Strategy director: Then we'll assess strategic options after the problem and evidence are properly defined.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

An executive asks for a "growth strategy" but has not specified whether the priority is revenue, profit, or market entry.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Which outcome are we trying to improve, over what period?
Revenue growth, profit improvement, and entry into a new market may require different choices. Let's define the decision first.

Scenario 2 | Efficiency has two meanings

In a fictional executive discussion, finance means lower total cost by efficiency, while operations means shorter customer waiting time. No preferred objective or numeric target is agreed.

Role A: You are the strategy facilitator. Clarify the two objectives and ask which decision the analysis should support.

Role B: You sponsor the work. Explain why the objectives may require different evidence and remain unprioritized.

Possible opening: Could we distinguish lower total cost from shorter waiting time before calling this one efficiency objective?

Success checks

- Name both meanings accurately.
- Keep the target and priority unagreed.
- Agree a bounded objective-setting question before choosing initiatives.

Add a complication: A participant wants a target announced immediately without a baseline.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Strategic Choices: Ambition, Where to Play, How to Win, and Tradeoffs

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

SITUATION

A team can invest in its core service or enter a new segment. The same staff would support both, and capacity is limited.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Strategic choice - Decision about where to focus, how to win, what to build, and what not to do.

Tradeoff - A deliberate decision to deprioritize one attractive option to make another choice coherent.

Activity system - Reinforcing set of activities that makes a strategy harder to copy.

Opportunity cost - Value sacrificed by keeping scarce resources in a lower-priority use.

3. Notice the language

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Improve this sentence: This option is more better.

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Explain a fair comparison

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence expresses a clear contrast?
 - A. Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.
 - B. Option A is faster because option B costs less.
 - C. Option A is faster, so option B costs less.
2. A rate increases from 6% to 7%. What is the absolute difference?
 - A. An increase of one percent relative to the original rate.
 - B. An increase of seven percentage points.
 - C. An increase of one percentage point.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Core improvement and market entry share the same people

The lesson's team can invest in its core service or enter a new segment; staff capacity is limited and shared.

01 • Strategy manager: Both options use the same limited staff. We can't compare them as if each had a separate team.

02 • Business sponsor: Could we call both priorities and ask people to deliver them alongside normal work?

03 • Strategy manager: That avoids the tradeoff rather than resolves it. The opportunity cost is what those people cannot do instead.

04 • Business sponsor: The core-service option strengthens existing work, whereas segment entry pursues a new customer group.

05 • Strategy manager: Yes. We should compare the same staffing period, expected outcomes, and uncertainty for both.

06 • Business sponsor: We haven't quantified those outcomes, so neither option has a proven higher return yet.

07 • Strategy manager: Correct. The activity system also matters: which supporting work each choice would require.

08 • Business sponsor: I'll ask both proposal owners to identify displaced work instead of hiding the resource conflict.

09 • Strategy manager: Then we can present a real strategic choice with common criteria and its weaker side visible.

10 • Business sponsor: Good. Our next discussion will prioritize, not simply add two labels to an overloaded team.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A focused pilot or a wider launch

Separate fictional strategy exercise: with the same six-person team for a quarter, option A serves one segment and includes research; B serves three segments but has no research capacity.

01 • Growth director: Option B reaches three segments, so it looks stronger than the one-segment pilot.

02 • Strategy analyst: Both use six people for the quarter, but only A includes capacity for customer research.

03 • Growth director: Then the tradeoff is broader initial coverage versus more deliberate learning in one segment.

04 • Strategy analyst: Exactly. More segments doesn't itself prove more profitable growth, especially with their needs still untested.

05 • Growth director: Could we keep B's reach and add A's research without changing the team?

06 • Strategy analyst: Not under these supplied options. We'd need to reassess scope rather than assume extra capacity.

07 • Growth director: I favor learning first, but want the lost early coverage stated as the opportunity cost.

08 • Strategy analyst: I'll make that explicit and retain the same quarterly staffing basis for the comparison.

09 • Growth director: Then the recommendation can explain a strategic choice instead of calling one option best at everything.

10 • Strategy analyst: Agreed. We can propose A for review while keeping its narrower reach visible.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Customization versus a repeatable service

Separate fictional strategy workshop: option A offers bespoke implementations with more configuration work; B standardizes the service but excludes some requested custom features. Revenue effects are unknown.

01 • Product director: The bespoke option answers more individual requests. Should we call it the obvious way to win?

02 • Operations strategist: It also requires more configuration work, whereas the standardized option excludes some custom features.

03 • Product director: So we should compare customer fit and delivery effort rather than count features alone.

04 • Operations strategist: Yes. Those choices imply different activity systems, not just different descriptions of the same offer.

05 • Product director: Do we know whether broader customization produces enough revenue to justify that work?

06 • Operations strategist: No. Revenue effects are unknown here, so neither margin advantage is established.

07 • Product director: I'll describe the opportunity cost of standardization as requests we deliberately don't support.

08 • Operations strategist: And describe the bespoke option's tradeoff as additional configuration work rather than free flexibility.

09 • Product director: Let's assess both over the same customer scope and planning horizon before recommending one.

10 • Operations strategist: Good. A useful strategic choice states what we give up as clearly as what we pursue.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Strategic Choices: Ambition, Where to Play, How to Win, and Tradeoffs

A team can invest in its core service or enter a new segment. The same staff would support both, and capacity is limited.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Second round: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for scenario 1: The two options compete for the same team. Expanding the core uses existing capabilities; entering the segment requires new ones. We should make the resource tradeoff explicit before selecting a direction.

Scenario 2 | Support hours or development capacity

A fictional team can allocate two specialists for the next quarter either to longer support hours or to a product improvement project. Existing hours and project scope would otherwise remain unchanged.

Role A: You are the strategy analyst. Compare the alternatives on the same staffing period.

Role B: You sponsor the decision. State a preferred benefit and acknowledge the work forgone.

Possible opening: The same two specialists can extend support or work on the improvement project, so choosing one displaces the other.

Success checks

- Keep the two-specialist quarterly constraint explicit.
- State the benefit and opportunity cost of each option.
- Offer a reviewable priority rather than promise both.

Add a complication: A stakeholder asks you to announce both outcomes without additional resources.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Industry Structure, Competitive Dynamics, and Profit Pools

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A market estimate is based on total industry spending, but the company can serve only one customer segment.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

TAM - Total addressable market; full demand opportunity if all relevant customers were served.

SAM - Serviceable available market; portion the company can realistically reach with its offer and model.

SOM - Serviceable obtainable market; share the company can reasonably capture.

Profit pool - Where profit accumulates across segments, value chain positions, or business models.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Improve this sentence: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change must have caused the delay.
 - B. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - C. The change may have contributed to the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. Across the service, the observed result was ...
 - B. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - C. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Industry spending exceeds the serviceable segment

The lesson's market estimate uses total industry spending, but the company can serve only one customer segment.

01 • Strategy analyst: The estimate uses total industry spending, while our current offer can serve only one customer segment.

02 • Executive sponsor: Can we present that total as the market we can realistically capture?

03 • Strategy analyst: No. Total addressable market and our serviceable market need to be distinguished before discussing obtainable share.

04 • Executive sponsor: So TAM, SAM, and SOM shouldn't all carry the same number by default.

05 • Strategy analyst: Correct. We haven't established the relevant segment size or a defensible obtainable share here.

06 • Executive sponsor: Could a large industry total still tell us where the profit pool sits?

07 • Strategy analyst: Not by itself. Spending volume doesn't identify where profits are earned within the industry.

08 • Executive sponsor: I'll keep the industry context but remove the claim that all of it is serviceable.

09 • Strategy analyst: I'll request segment evidence and clarify which assumptions would support an obtainable-market estimate.

10 • Executive sponsor: Good. The opportunity statement should match our actual reach rather than a broad headline number.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A market-share aspiration is not a sales forecast

Separate fictional sizing exercise: a serviceable market is estimated at \$20 million, and a team proposes a 5% share target without acquisition evidence.

01 • Business development lead: Five percent of the twenty-million-dollar estimate is one million. Can we call that next year's sales forecast?

02 • Strategy researcher: The arithmetic works, but the five-percent share is an aspiration without acquisition evidence.

03 • Business development lead: Then the one-million-dollar figure is conditional on an unsupported share assumption.

04 • Strategy researcher: Exactly. A serviceable market estimate doesn't establish an obtainable market or a timed revenue forecast.

05 • Business development lead: What would make the SOM discussion more grounded than selecting a convenient percentage?

06 • Strategy researcher: Evidence about reach, capacity, conversion, and relevant competition, with the assumptions stated explicitly.

07 • Business development lead: We haven't supplied those inputs, so I'll present the share as a proposed target only.

08 • Strategy researcher: Also preserve uncertainty in the twenty-million-dollar estimate rather than treat it as exact measured demand.

09 • Business development lead: I'll separate market estimate, share ambition, and sales forecast in the meeting.

10 • Strategy researcher: Good. That prevents correct multiplication from disguising an unsupported commercial conclusion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

More revenue does not locate the profit pool

Separate fictional industry exercise: distribution has higher reported revenue than specialist servicing, but comparable cost data is unavailable.

01 • Strategy associate: Distribution reports more revenue than specialist servicing. Is that where the largest profit pool must be?

02 • Strategy director: Not necessarily. Revenue and profit differ, and comparable cost data isn't available here.

03 • Strategy associate: So industry scale doesn't by itself establish where value is retained after costs.

04 • Strategy director: Correct. We also need comparable business boundaries before interpreting the two reported figures.

05 • Strategy associate: Could we assume servicing has higher margins because it sounds more specialized?

06 • Strategy director: No. That would substitute a plausible story for evidence about actual economics.

07 • Strategy associate: I'll describe the observed revenue difference and identify profitability as an open question.

08 • Strategy director: Good. Our market-entry discussion should not treat an unmeasured profit pool as confirmed.

09 • Strategy associate: I'll seek comparable cost and scope information before recommending where to compete.

10 • Strategy director: Then the analysis can distinguish industry structure evidence from assumptions about attractive returns.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Industry Structure, Competitive Dynamics, and Profit Pools

A market estimate is based on total industry spending, but the company can serve only one customer segment.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: Total industry spending is broader than our addressable opportunity. I'll separate the overall market from the segment we can serve and explain the assumptions used to estimate our potential share.

Scenario 2 | Global spending with a regional offer

A fictional market slide uses a global spending estimate, but the company's current service is available in one region. That region's share of spending is unmeasured.

Role A: You review the sizing. Explain the gap between global context and current serviceability.

Role B: You prepared the slide. Identify the regional evidence needed without inventing a share.

Possible opening: The global figure provides context, but it doesn't establish the market our current regional offer can serve.

Success checks

- Distinguish global spending from current reach.
- Reject an unsupported equal-share assumption.
- Agree a regional evidence request and qualified sizing statement.

Add a complication: A sponsor suggests dividing the global estimate equally among regions despite no supporting evidence.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Business Models, Unit Economics, Capabilities, and Advantage

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

A new service has positive revenue growth but negative contribution after variable delivery costs. A slide calls growth proof of a sound business model.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Value driver - Factor that materially affects enterprise value, such as growth, margin, capital intensity, or risk.

ROIC - Return on invested capital; profit relative to capital invested in the business.

Margin expansion - Improvement in profitability as a share of revenue.

Right to win - Credible basis for outperforming alternatives in that market.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Improve this sentence: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
 - B. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
 - C. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. How would you describe the next step in your own words?
 - B. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?
 - C. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Growth with negative contribution

The lesson's new service has rising revenue but negative contribution after variable delivery costs; a slide calls growth proof of a sound model.

01 • Business unit director: Revenue is growing. Why can't we call that proof of a sound business model?

02 • Strategy finance lead: The service has negative contribution after variable delivery costs, so growth alone doesn't establish sound economics.

03 • Business unit director: Could you explain contribution in terms the operating team will recognize?

04 • Strategy finance lead: Here, it's revenue minus those variable delivery costs, before considering the other costs not included.

05 • Business unit director: So more sales can coexist with an unfavorable contribution, rather than automatically create margin expansion.

06 • Strategy finance lead: Exactly. We need to understand the value drivers and costs before claiming profitable scaling.

07 • Business unit director: Does negative contribution alone settle our long-term right to win in the market?

08 • Strategy finance lead: No. That broader capability question also needs evidence; neither conclusion follows from revenue growth alone.

09 • Business unit director: I'll separate demand growth from the unresolved economic and capability questions.

10 • Strategy finance lead: Good. The slide should explain what improved and what still undermines the model.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A contribution calculation before fixed costs

Separate fictional service example: each job earns \$80 and incurs \$50 variable delivery cost; fixed overhead and invested capital are not supplied.

01 • Service director: Each job earns eighty dollars and costs fifty in variable delivery. Is thirty dollars our final profit?

02 • Strategy analyst: It is contribution per job in this example, not final profit after all costs.

03 • Service director: Because fixed overhead hasn't been deducted from that thirty-dollar difference.

04 • Strategy analyst: Correct. And we haven't supplied invested capital, so this doesn't establish return on invested capital, or ROIC.

05 • Service director: Then a useful value driver might be delivery efficiency, but we still need evidence about feasible improvements.

06 • Strategy analyst: Exactly. A smaller variable cost would change contribution in the model, not prove an improvement has occurred.

07 • Service director: I'll explain the eighty-minus-fifty calculation and keep the missing overhead visible.

08 • Strategy analyst: Good. That lets colleagues understand unit economics without mistaking one layer for complete profitability.

09 • Service director: We'll discuss margin expansion only with the relevant cost basis and assumptions clear.

10 • Strategy analyst: Agreed. The simple calculation should illuminate the model, not conceal its incomplete inputs.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Owning data is not yet a right to win

Separate fictional strategy review: a company owns a historical service dataset but has not tested its usefulness for a proposed analytics product.

01 • Product strategist: We own the historical dataset. Doesn't that give us a right to win in analytics?

02 • Strategy director: It may be an asset, but we haven't tested its usefulness for the proposed customer problem.

03 • Product strategist: So a resource is something we possess, while a capability is what we can reliably do with it.

04 • Strategy director: Exactly. Advantage also depends on whether that capability creates relevant value compared with alternatives.

05 • Product strategist: Could we call the dataset a proven value driver before customers use the proposed product?

06 • Strategy director: Not on this evidence. Its relevance and practical usefulness remain hypotheses to assess.

07 • Product strategist: I'll describe the dataset as a potential input, not proof of a defensible business model.

08 • Strategy director: Good. Also identify any usage constraints before assuming every record is available for the new purpose.

09 • Product strategist: We'll test usefulness and clarify constraints before presenting a right-to-win claim.

10 • Strategy director: That distinguishes a promising resource from demonstrated capability and competitive advantage.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Business Models, Unit Economics, Capabilities, and Advantage

A new service has positive revenue growth but negative contribution after variable delivery costs. A slide calls growth proof of a sound business model.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: Growth shows demand, but it does not by itself demonstrate attractive unit economics. Let's explain the revenue and variable costs per unit before drawing conclusions about the model.

Scenario 2 | Automation savings exclude support work

A fictional service model shows ten minutes less manual processing per job, but any additional support work has not been measured. A slide claims total delivery cost fell.

Role A: You explain unit economics. Separate observed processing time from full delivery cost.

Role B: You own operations. Ask what support and cost evidence is needed to assess margin improvement.

Possible opening: Processing takes ten fewer minutes, but total delivery cost hasn't been established without the support work.

Success checks

- Preserve the ten-minute observation.
- Distinguish task time, delivery cost, and profit.
- Agree to measure missing work before claiming margin expansion.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call the time difference a verified profit increase.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Portfolio Strategy, Capital Allocation, and Resource Reallocation

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

SITUATION

Two divisions request the same investment budget. Neither proposal explains what work would stop if it were funded.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Capital allocation - Decision process for assigning capital to businesses, initiatives, acquisitions, or returns.

Core business - Current business central to revenue, profit, capabilities, or strategic identity.

Divestiture - Sale, exit, or separation of a business, asset, or product line.

Adjacency - Growth area near the core by customer, channel, capability, geography, or value chain.

3. Notice the language

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Improve this sentence: If you will approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Offer a workable tradeoff

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence presents a normal future condition clearly?
 - A. If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.
 - B. If the scope will change, we will review the schedule.
 - C. If the scope changes, we reviewed the schedule.
2. Which response negotiates a new request without silently promising extra work?
 - A. We have included it, although its scope has not been reviewed.
 - B. We guarantee the original date without assessing the addition.
 - C. We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Two investment requests need displaced-work choices

The lesson's two divisions request the same investment budget; neither explains what work would stop if funded.

01 • Portfolio director: Both divisions request the same investment budget. What would each stop or defer if it were funded?

02 • Division sponsor: Neither proposal identifies displaced work. We presented them as additions to the current portfolio.

03 • Portfolio director: Then capital allocation isn't fully described. The resource tradeoff needs to be explicit.

04 • Division sponsor: Could we approve the preferred proposal first and decide what to stop later?

05 • Portfolio director: We can take it for review, but shouldn't promise resources without examining the competing commitments.

06 • Division sponsor: I'll ask each division for a funded option and the work it would defer.

07 • Portfolio director: Good. Distinguish protecting the core business from exploring an adjacency, without assuming one always wins.

08 • Division sponsor: We'll also identify approvals required before either option becomes a commitment.

09 • Portfolio director: Then we can negotiate scope or sequencing with the consequences visible.

10 • Division sponsor: Agreed. The next review will contain choices, not two requests that both assume the full budget.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Funding a pilot by deferring a rollout

Separate fictional portfolio exercise: a team has a fixed \$100,000 budget. A \$20,000 adjacency pilot could be funded only by reducing a planned \$100,000 core rollout to \$80,000; approval is pending.

01 • Innovation sponsor: Could we fund the twenty-thousand-dollar adjacency pilot within the existing hundred-thousand-dollar budget?

02 • Portfolio manager: Only by reducing the planned core rollout to eighty thousand under this proposal.

03 • Innovation sponsor: Then my offer is a smaller pilot funded through a defined reduction, not extra money.

04 • Portfolio manager: Yes. What core rollout work would the twenty-thousand-dollar reduction actually defer?

05 • Innovation sponsor: That scope hasn't been identified yet, so I can't claim the core business is unaffected.

06 • Portfolio manager: Please obtain that detail before we ask for approval of the capital allocation.

07 • Innovation sponsor: If the reduced rollout is acceptable, can we take both linked scopes for review?

08 • Portfolio manager: Yes, as a conditional proposal. I can't confirm approval or resource release today.

09 • Innovation sponsor: I'll keep the two budgets together and show the deferred work once assessed.

10 • Portfolio manager: Good. The funding conversation will expose the tradeoff instead of presenting the pilot as free.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A divestiture idea cannot fund spending yet

Separate fictional portfolio review: a team proposes selling a noncore unit to fund investment, but no buyer, valuation, or sale timing is confirmed.

01 • Business sponsor: Could we commit the new investment now and pay for it from the planned divestiture?

02 • Capital allocation lead: The sale is only a proposal. Buyer, value, and timing are all unconfirmed.

03 • Business sponsor: Then what can we offer the investment team without promising unavailable proceeds?

04 • Capital allocation lead: We can assess a staged proposal with funding conditions explicit, rather than authorize the full spend.

05 • Business sponsor: Would the first stage also need its own identified funding and approval?

06 • Capital allocation lead: Yes. Calling a stage small doesn't create budget or remove the decision requirement.

07 • Business sponsor: I'll request a bounded scope and distinguish its funding from the hypothetical sale.

08 • Capital allocation lead: Good. Keep the noncore-unit review separate from any conclusion that divestiture is already agreed.

09 • Business sponsor: Then our recommendation can present the dependency and alternative sequencing for decision.

10 • Capital allocation lead: Exactly. Negotiate what can be assessed now without converting a possible transaction into cash on hand.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Portfolio Strategy, Capital Allocation, and Resource Reallocation

Two divisions request the same investment budget. Neither proposal explains what work would stop if it were funded.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Second round: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Model for scenario 1: Could each division identify the expected benefit, key assumption, and activity it would deprioritize? That would let us compare the proposals as allocation choices rather than separate wish lists.

Scenario 2 | Shared specialists block two funded projects

Two fictional portfolio projects each have budget approval, but both require the same specialist during the same month. Only one month's specialist capacity is available; project sequencing is undecided.

Role A: You manage the portfolio. Explain why funding approval doesn't resolve the staffing conflict.

Role B: You sponsor one project. Offer a sequencing proposal and state what would be delayed.

Possible opening: Both budgets are approved, but the shared specialist cannot cover both projects in the same month.

Success checks

- Separate budget from specialist capacity.
- Offer a concrete sequencing tradeoff.
- Keep the changed delivery commitments subject to review.

Add a complication: A sponsor asks you to confirm parallel delivery because the money is already allocated.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Growth Strategy, Market Entry, Partnerships, and M&A Logic

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

An acquisition proposal lists possible cost savings. No integration plan or implementation estimate has been prepared.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Market entry - Plan to enter a new geography, segment, category, or value-chain position.

Build-buy-partner - Comparison of internal development, acquisition, and partnership routes.

Synergy - Incremental value from combining businesses, assets, capabilities, customers, or costs.

PMI - Post-merger integration; work required to combine and realize value after a deal.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Improve this sentence: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change must have caused the delay.
 - B. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - C. The change may have contributed to the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. Across the service, the observed result was ...
 - B. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - C. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Possible synergies without an integration estimate

The lesson's acquisition proposal lists possible cost savings but has no integration plan or implementation estimate.

01 • Acquisition sponsor: The proposal lists cost savings. Can we present them as the acquisition's confirmed value creation?

02 • Strategy lead: No. They are possible synergies, and we lack an integration plan and implementation estimate.

03 • Acquisition sponsor: Then gross savings and net benefit are different claims in this discussion.

04 • Strategy lead: Exactly. Post-merger integration, or PMI, may require costs and work that aren't estimated here.

05 • Acquisition sponsor: Could we assume integration is straightforward because the businesses look similar?

06 • Strategy lead: Similarity isn't evidence that systems, roles, and operating processes will combine easily.

07 • Acquisition sponsor: I'll label the savings as proposed and identify the missing implementation work.

08 • Strategy lead: Good. The build-buy-partner comparison should include realistic execution assumptions for each route.

09 • Acquisition sponsor: We'll seek integration input before treating the acquisition as the proven best growth option.

10 • Strategy lead: Then leadership can distinguish strategic logic from benefits that still need validation and delivery.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A partnership discussion is not secured market access

Separate fictional market-entry exercise: a potential distributor has expressed interest, but no agreement, coverage commitment, or commercial terms are established.

01 • Market entry director: The distributor is interested. Can the strategy update say we've secured access to the market?

02 • Partnerships lead: Not yet. Interest isn't an agreement, and coverage commitments and commercial terms remain open.

03 • Market entry director: Then the partner route is a potential option, not a completed market-entry capability.

04 • Partnerships lead: Correct. We should also assess what the distributor can actually deliver rather than infer reach from enthusiasm.

05 • Market entry director: Could we include projected sales as guaranteed because a channel conversation is underway?

06 • Partnerships lead: No. That would add certainty unsupported by either the relationship or demand evidence.

07 • Market entry director: I'll report the discussion milestone and the unresolved commercial questions separately.

08 • Partnerships lead: Good. We can compare build, buy, and partner routes without calling the partner route secured.

09 • Market entry director: Please bring the next evidence needed for a credible coverage assessment.

10 • Partnerships lead: I will, with any scenario assumptions clearly separated from confirmed commitments.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Overlapping teams do not prove removable costs

Separate fictional acquisition exercise: both firms have customer-support teams, but workload, service requirements, and integration costs have not been assessed.

01 • Deal analyst: Both firms have support teams. Can we count one team's cost as an automatic synergy?

02 • Integration manager: No. Overlapping job labels don't show that the combined workload can be handled by one team.

03 • Deal analyst: So the observation is duplication of functions, not confirmed removable capacity.

04 • Integration manager: Exactly. We need workload, service requirements, and implementation costs before estimating a defensible net benefit.

05 • Deal analyst: Would using a standard percentage reduction make the estimate more credible?

06 • Integration manager: Only if it has relevant support. A convenient percentage doesn't replace an integration assessment.

07 • Deal analyst: I'll describe a potential support-efficiency opportunity and keep the savings amount unestablished.

08 • Integration manager: Good. PMI planning also needs to consider service continuity rather than treat every overlap as unnecessary.

09 • Deal analyst: We'll request the operational evidence before including a firm saving in the acquisition case.

10 • Integration manager: Then the synergy discussion can move from a plausible idea to an assessed proposal.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Growth Strategy, Market Entry, Partnerships, and M&A Logic

An acquisition proposal lists possible cost savings. No integration plan or implementation estimate has been prepared.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: These are potential synergies, not confirmed savings. I'll distinguish the opportunity from the work and cost required to achieve it so the proposal presents a balanced strategic case.

Scenario 2 | A build estimate excludes customer support

A fictional build-buy-partner comparison prices the build option's software development but omits ongoing customer support. The other options include support estimates. No preferred route is approved.

Role A: You review the strategy case. Identify the scope mismatch and limit the cost conclusion.

Role B: You own the build proposal. Ask for support requirements and retain the estimate as partial.

Possible opening: The build figure excludes customer support, so it isn't yet comparable with the other two estimates.

Success checks

- Identify the omitted support scope.
- Keep the build total and route preference unconfirmed.
- Agree a consistent-scope assessment before ranking options.

Add a complication: A sponsor wants to call building the cheapest route before the missing work is costed.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Uncertainty, Scenarios, Strategic Options, and Risk Posture

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

SITUATION

A planning workshop has a base case and a downside case. The team wants to call one a prediction.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Scenario planning - Structured analysis of plausible futures and their implications for decisions.

Residual uncertainty - Uncertainty remaining after strong analysis has been completed.

Trigger indicator - Signal that shows which scenario may be unfolding and when to revisit a decision.

Strategic option - Limited investment that preserves future ability to scale, pivot, or exit.

3. Notice the language

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Improve this sentence: This option is more better.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Explain a fair comparison

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence expresses a clear contrast?
 - A. Option A is faster, so option B costs less.
 - B. Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.
 - C. Option A is faster because option B costs less.
2. A rate increases from 6% to 7%. What is the absolute difference?
 - A. An increase of one percentage point.
 - B. An increase of one percent relative to the original rate.
 - C. An increase of seven percentage points.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Comparing scenarios without naming a prediction

Separate fictional quarterly planning exercise: option A reserves capacity for 100 jobs at a total quarterly cost of \$10,000; B reserves 60 jobs for \$6,000. Both cover the same service and quarter. Base-case demand is 90 jobs; downside demand is 50. Demand figures are assumptions, and revenue is unestimated.

01 • Planning sponsor: The base case assumes ninety jobs this quarter; the downside assumes fifty. Which is our prediction?

02 • Strategy facilitator: Neither is established as a prediction. Let's compare both capacity options under those assumptions.

03 • Planning sponsor: A provides one hundred slots for ten thousand dollars, while B provides sixty for six thousand.

04 • Strategy facilitator: In the base case, A covers ninety jobs; B leaves thirty beyond its reserved capacity.

05 • Planning sponsor: In the downside case, both cover fifty, but A has fifty unused slots and B ten.

06 • Strategy facilitator: Correct. A costs four thousand more for the same quarter but accommodates higher demand.

07 • Planning sponsor: So B limits committed cost, whereas A provides more capacity if the base case occurs.

08 • Strategy facilitator: Yes. Revenue is unestimated, so this comparison doesn't establish which option would be more profitable.

09 • Planning sponsor: Let's take that cost-capacity tradeoff for review instead of calling either scenario certain.

10 • Strategy facilitator: Agreed. We'll retain both demand assumptions and the residual uncertainty in the recommendation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A short lease preserves flexibility at a higher cost

Separate fictional strategy exercise: a one-year facility option costs more annually but preserves an earlier exit; a three-year option costs less annually but commits longer. Other terms are unassessed.

01 • Operations director: The three-year option is cheaper annually. Should we choose it under both demand scenarios?

02 • Strategy analyst: It also commits us longer, whereas the one-year option costs more but preserves an earlier exit.

03 • Operations director: Then the strategic option we're comparing includes flexibility, not simply annual price.

04 • Strategy analyst: Exactly. Under uncertain demand, the ability to reconsider earlier may matter, but its value isn't quantified here.

05 • Operations director: Could we say the short option is always safer without checking the other terms?

06 • Strategy analyst: No. Other terms remain unassessed, and different scenarios may make the tradeoff look different.

07 • Operations director: I'll compare annual cost and commitment length consistently, with demand assumptions stated.

08 • Strategy analyst: Good. Don't compare one year's total with three years' total as though the periods match.

09 • Operations director: We'll review the remaining terms before recommending how much flexibility to preserve.

10 • Strategy analyst: Then the decision can acknowledge both the price advantage and the longer commitment it buys.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A review trigger is not an automatic expansion order

Separate fictional plan: two consecutive months above a demand threshold trigger strategy review, not automatic expansion. Only one month qualifies. For the coming month, preparation-only would cost \$2,000 for a capacity assessment and create no external contract; immediate expansion would cost \$12,000 monthly under a six-month capacity contract. Neither option is approved.

01 • Commercial sponsor: Demand crossed the threshold once. Can we expand next month instead of only preparing?

02 • Strategy manager: The trigger requires two consecutive months and initiates review, not automatic expansion. Neither option is approved.

03 • Commercial sponsor: Compare the coming month's commitments so I can see what each option actually involves.

04 • Strategy manager: Preparation costs two thousand dollars for an assessment; expansion costs twelve thousand for capacity next month.

05 • Commercial sponsor: That's ten thousand more next month. Does expansion also commit us beyond that period?

06 • Strategy manager: Yes, twelve thousand monthly for six months. Preparation creates no external contract, but adds no capacity.

07 • Commercial sponsor: So preparation preserves flexibility, whereas expansion supplies capacity sooner with a longer financial commitment.

08 • Strategy manager: Exactly. One qualifying month doesn't establish sustained demand or justify treating either option as authorized.

09 • Commercial sponsor: I'll take preparation as my preferred proposal for review, with the capacity limitation explicit.

10 • Strategy manager: I'll record that preference, not approval. The second demand month and any spending decision remain pending.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Uncertainty, Scenarios, Strategic Options, and Risk Posture

A planning workshop has a base case and a downside case. The team wants to call one a prediction.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Second round: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for scenario 1: These scenarios explore different conditions; neither is a promise about the future. Let's identify the signals we would monitor and which decisions we would revisit if conditions changed.

Scenario 2 | A reversible pilot versus a permanent rollout

A fictional strategy team compares a three-month pilot that can be stopped at review with a permanent rollout requiring a longer commitment. Costs and customer outcomes are not yet estimated.

Role A: You are the strategy analyst. Compare commitment and learning while preserving missing economic information.

Role B: You sponsor the choice. Explain which flexibility matters and ask what would trigger further investment.

Possible opening: The pilot provides an earlier review point, whereas the rollout commits us longer; their costs remain unestimated.

Success checks

- State the three-month review point and longer rollout commitment.
- Avoid claiming reversibility removes all risk or cost.
- Agree evidence needed for the next investment decision.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call the pilot risk-free because it can be stopped.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Execution Governance, Operating Model, KPIs, and Board Narrative

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

SITUATION

A board presentation has twelve metrics but no clear request. The sponsor needs approval for a limited pilot.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Operating model - How structure, roles, processes, governance, incentives, and capabilities support strategy.

Decision rights - Clarity on who recommends, decides, executes, and escalates.

KPI - Key performance indicator tied to a strategic objective or decision.

Board narrative - Concise strategy story for oversight, alignment, and decision-making.

3. Notice the language

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Improve this sentence: Nobody objected, so everyone agrees.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Help a group reach a clear next step

4. Check the language

1. Which phrase invites a missing perspective?
 - A. We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?
 - B. The remote team has been quiet, so they must agree.
 - C. We can record their agreement without asking them.
2. Which closing statement records an unresolved decision accurately?
 - A. We discussed the options, so approval is complete.
 - B. Everyone spoke, so the decision must be final.
 - C. Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Twelve metrics and one missing request

Separate fictional extension of the lesson: a twelve-metric board presentation seeks approval for a four-week, twenty-account pilot. Operations estimates ten support hours weekly, but only six are available. Additional staffing and pilot approval are unconfirmed; the board holds approval authority.

01 • Strategy director: Our twelve metrics don't state the request. What decision are we asking the board to make?

02 • Executive sponsor: Approval for a four-week pilot with twenty accounts, not a permanent rollout or immediate expansion.

03 • Strategy director: Before presenting that request, operations, what constraint does the board need to hear?

04 • Operations lead: The pilot needs ten support hours weekly, but we have six. Four hours remain uncovered.

05 • Strategy director: So the proposed scope exceeds available support. Can we assume colleagues will absorb those four hours?

06 • Operations lead: No. Additional staffing is unconfirmed. We should assess extra coverage or a smaller pilot scope.

07 • Strategy director: That makes support capacity an unresolved condition. Sponsor, will you own presenting the conditional request?

08 • Executive sponsor: Yes. I'll present the scope and coverage gap, with board approval explicitly pending.

09 • Strategy director: Operations, please own the coverage-options assessment before that discussion. Can you confirm the handoff?

10 • Operations lead: I accept that assessment. I'll return feasible options, not promise additional staffing; pilot approval remains pending.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A KPI owner is not automatically the decision owner

Separate fictional pilot: conversion improved, and analytics owns reporting that KPI. The sponsor alone decides extension. A proposed fifty-client extension requires twenty support hours weekly; operations has twelve available. Additional coverage is unconfirmed, and extension is unapproved.

01 • Program manager: Conversion improved. Can analytics announce the proposed fifty-client extension, or is another decision needed?

02 • Analytics lead: I own the KPI report, not extension approval. The sponsor holds that decision right.

03 • Program manager: Operations, what would supporting fifty clients require, and what capacity do you actually have?

04 • Operations lead: We need twenty support hours weekly and have twelve available. Eight hours remain uncovered.

05 • Program manager: Then improved conversion doesn't resolve delivery capacity. Would a smaller scope or extra coverage need assessment?

06 • Operations lead: Yes. Neither solution is confirmed, so we cannot promise support for fifty clients yet.

07 • Program manager: Analytics, please provide the measured result without an approval claim. Can you own that part?

08 • Analytics lead: Yes. I'll provide the KPI evidence and distinguish it from the sponsor's pending extension decision.

09 • Program manager: Operations, will you own assessing coverage or reduced scope? We'll present that gap alongside the KPI.

10 • Operations lead: I accept the assessment and will return the options. The fifty-client extension remains unapproved pending the sponsor's review.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A steering meeting ends with an unresolved owner

Separate fictional execution review: commercial and operations teams each assume the other owns customer onboarding in a proposed service; no ownership decision has been made.

01 • Steering chair: Commercial and operations each expect the other to own onboarding. We need to resolve that operating-model question.

02 • Program director: Could we list both teams as owners and move to the next agenda item?

03 • Steering chair: Shared participation doesn't explain who is accountable for the decision and the actual handoff.

04 • Program director: Then we should hear what each team can own before proposing an allocation.

05 • Steering chair: Exactly. Invite both perspectives, including any capacity constraints we haven't assessed.

06 • Program director: Who can confirm the final ownership arrangement after that discussion?

07 • Steering chair: That decision right hasn't been established in this exercise. We need the sponsor to clarify it.

08 • Program director: I'll record that as a specific action rather than infer agreement because nobody objected.

09 • Steering chair: Good. Close with onboarding ownership unresolved and the sponsor clarification assigned to you.

10 • Program director: I accept that action and won't describe the operating model as approved until the decision is confirmed.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Execution Governance, Operating Model, KPIs, and Board Narrative

A board presentation has twelve metrics but no clear request. The sponsor needs approval for a limited pilot.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Second round: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Model for scenario 1: The decision today is whether to authorize the pilot. I'll lead with that request, the proposed scope, and the measures for reviewing it, then use the remaining metrics as supporting detail.

Scenario 2 | A board discussion praised the pilot but did not approve expansion

A fictional board discussion praised pilot learning but deferred the expansion decision until costs are reviewed. The draft internal update says expansion approved. Finance has not supplied the cost review.

Role A: You facilitate the follow-up. Restate the actual decision and invite finance's missing input.

Role B: You sponsor the pilot. Confirm the deferred decision and identify who will bring the cost review.

Possible opening: The board welcomed the learning but deferred expansion pending the cost review; approval has not been given.

Success checks

- Separate positive discussion from approval.
- Identify the pending finance input.
- Close with accurate decision status and a named follow-up responsibility.

Add a complication: A team lead wants to begin expansion because the feedback sounded positive.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: B - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

B: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

C: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

Check 2: A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

B: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

C: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

Model response: Which outcome are we trying to improve, over what period? Revenue growth, profit improvement, and entry into a new market may require different choices. Let's define the decision first.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Strategic Choices: Ambition, Where to Play, How to Win, and Tradeoffs

Editing example: This option is better on cost, but slower to deliver.

'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Check 1: A - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.

A: 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

B: 'Because' claims a causal connection that is not given.

C: 'So' implies one fact causes the other.

Check 2: C - An increase of one percentage point.

A: A one-percent relative increase on 6% would be 6.06%, not 7%.

B: The new rate is 7%; the difference between the rates is one percentage point.

C: Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

Model response: The two options compete for the same team. Expanding the core uses existing capabilities; entering the segment requires new ones. We should make the resource tradeoff explicit before selecting a direction.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Industry Structure, Competitive Dynamics, and Profit Pools

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: C - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

B: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

C: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

Check 2: B - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

B: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

C: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

Model response: Total industry spending is broader than our addressable opportunity. I'll separate the overall market from the segment we can serve and explain the assumptions used to estimate our potential share.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Business Models, Unit Economics, Capabilities, and Advantage

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

B: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

C: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

Check 2: A - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

B: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

C: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

Model response: Growth shows demand, but it does not by itself demonstrate attractive unit economics. Let's explain the revenue and variable costs per unit before drawing conclusions about the model.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Portfolio Strategy, Capital Allocation, and Resource Reallocation

Editing example: If you approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Check 1: A - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.

A: The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.

B: For this ordinary future condition, use present simple in the "if" clause.

C: "Reviewed" places the response in the past instead of expressing the future response.

Check 2: C - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.

A: It treats unreviewed work as already included.

B: It promises an outcome without examining the consequences.

C: This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

Model response: Could each division identify the expected benefit, key assumption, and activity it would deprioritize? That would let us compare the proposals as allocation choices rather than separate wish lists.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Growth Strategy, Market Entry, Partnerships, and M&A Logic

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: C - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

B: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

C: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

Check 2: B - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

B: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

C: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

Model response: These are potential synergies, not confirmed savings. I'll distinguish the opportunity from the work and cost required to achieve it so the proposal presents a balanced strategic case.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Uncertainty, Scenarios, Strategic Options, and Risk Posture

Editing example: This option is better on cost, but slower to deliver.

'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Check 1: B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.

A: 'So' implies one fact causes the other.

B: 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

C: 'Because' claims a causal connection that is not given.

Check 2: A - An increase of one percentage point.

A: Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

B: A one-percent relative increase on 6% would be 6.06%, not 7%.

C: The new rate is 7%; the difference between the rates is one percentage point.

Model response: These scenarios explore different conditions; neither is a promise about the future. Let's identify the signals we would monitor and which decisions we would revisit if conditions changed.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Execution Governance, Operating Model, KPIs, and Board Narrative

Editing example: Before I record agreement, does anyone have a concern or need more time?

The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Check 1: A - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?

A: It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.

B: Silence does not establish agreement.

C: Recording agreement without checking may misrepresent the team's view.

Check 2: C - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.

A: Discussion does not itself constitute approval.

B: Participation alone does not establish a decision.

C: This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

Model response: The decision today is whether to authorize the pilot. I'll lead with that request, the proposed scope, and the measures for reviewing it, then use the remaining metrics as supporting detail.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Corporate Strategy English

Professional audience: corporate strategy, CEO office, transformation, corporate development, strategic finance, product strategy, and internal consulting teams

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

Original fictional case: An executive asks for a "growth strategy" but has not specified whether the priority is revenue, profit, or market entry.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: Diagnosis: Explanation of the strategic problem, its cause, and why it matters now. / Ambition: High-level performance or market position the company wants to achieve. / Strategic thesis: Argument for why a course of action should create advantage or value. / Issue tree: Structured breakdown of a problem into analyzable questions.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Which outcome are we trying to improve, over what period? Revenue growth, profit improvement, and entry into a new market may require different choices. Let's define the decision first.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Get feedback on a draft

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

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Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Which outcome are we trying to improve, over what period? Revenue growth, profit improvement, and entry into a new market may require different choices. Let's define the decision first.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Coach my workplace writing

1. Ask me to paste my own fictional or anonymized draft and identify its reader and purpose. If the reference gives a writing task, mention that task as the default. If it is a dialogue, suggest a brief follow-up message that records its outcome and open questions. Stop and wait. Do not write the message for me first.
2. Once I supply the draft, check it against the reference. If an ambiguity changes the meaning, ask one focused question before rewriting. Do not assume that the draft is correct evidence for a new deadline, approval, diagnosis, cost or commitment.
3. Give feedback in three parts: one effective phrase with a reason; up to three priority improvements, quoting my words; and one short revision task for me. Prioritize incorrect facts or unclear action before minor grammar. For each language correction, explain why it matters to this reader. Label optional stylistic alternatives separately and preserve my level of certainty and intended politeness.
4. Stop and wait for my revision. Then compare the two attempts, identify an improvement and offer one edited version that preserves my voice and purpose. Keep the requested length; if none is specified, use 70-110 words. Explain any meaningful change rather than silently making the message stronger or more certain.
5. Close with one phrase worth reusing and a short transfer task for a different fictional reader. Wait for my attempt before providing another model.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level